The Jewel Ornament of Liberation — verses

Khenchen Rinpoche, Impermanence (0:00–59:34). Points as shown on the slides, set as verses, in the order they appear in the video.

0. All composite phenomena are impermanent [1:39–10:26]

Meditation on Impermanence as great healing

1. I will read a few lines and explain,
   and then you can read more details.
   Of these, the first instruction is
   the meditation on impermanence as
   the antidote/remedy to attachment
   to this life.

2. *"All composite phenomena…"*
   Composite phenomena are produced through
   many causes and conditions, which then
   produce one. Just like a writing pen:
   the pen is composed of, or a product of,
   many causes and conditions. So Buddha
   said all those are impermanent.

3. *"O monks, all composite phenomena are*
   impermanent." Monks and nuns need a
   lot of reminders of impermanence.
   Wearing Dharma robes without
   contemplating impermanence is not so
   good. So then, mental afflictions come;
   attachment comes, and the fighting.

4. So, to hundreds of thousands of
   monks and nuns the Buddha said:
   "O monks and nuns, all composite
   phenomena are impermanent." Then all the
   bubbling of the mind just slows down.
   All the attachment around there is
   lessened, and the mind becomes more
   peaceful, physically more peaceful.
   We just reflect and meditate on this.

5. Just meditate on it.
   For example, when there's deep
   suffering, meditate on impermanence.
   Take a deep breath: everything is
   impermanent. When you are taking all
   your attention to the suffering,
   this helps to release the suffering,
   "Oh, the suffering is not permanent,
   it will change." Meditate.

6. When strong anger arises,
   meditate on impermanence. The person to
   whom you have the anger is impermanent.
   So, "Why are you so vicious about
   your anger to that person?"
   It helps to release that power.

7. It's very easy to do but it's very
   important to do off and on. Just sit,
   just take a deep breath and meditate.
   When you are next to a tree, the wind
   blows, the tree moves making noise;
   meditate, "Oh, this is impermanent, it's
   changing, everything has this nature."
   While I talk about impermanence,
   please meditate on this.

8. Meditating on impermanence is great
   healing. It's not a negative thing.
   Whether we contemplate on impermanence
   or not, we are impermanent anyway.

9. Those who don't believe in
impermanence are impermanent anyway.
No choice. Sometimes some people say,
"Impermanence is such a negative
thought, let us have a more positive…
don't think about impermanence."
But it is impermanent anyway.

10. Now in the world, wives and husbands,
when they disagree so much,
they divorce — one, two, three times.
And there are some who have very good
relationships, so peaceful, so grateful
— they spend their whole life together.
But at the end of their life there's so
much suffering: "I lost my husband/wife.
We were so good together, we loved each
other so much. I miss him/her so much."
And the pain is so much, in the mind,
in the heart.

11. Now I'm getting old,
and so are many of my friends.
Sometimes they are writing "Can you say
prayers so that in their next life they
can meet my husband, my wife again."
What should I say, really?
Attachment is that pain, so much.

12. Impermanence is not about being
careless. As I mentioned,
you care for each other, you help
each other, you support each other —
but look at impermanence, practice.
When you have impermanence,
you are prepared, and also you can
live more peacefully.

13. So, "You are impermanent,
I'm impermanent, let's live
peacefully, without fighting."
Then you can get so much benefit, and
remind each other of Dharma practice:
"It's not just only this life —
let's practice for enlightenment,
for buddhahood, for the benefit
of all sentient beings."
Like that, impermanence has such
powerful instructions.

0. The end of accumulation is dispersion [10:26–13:45]

Instead, practice gratitude

1. Now, there are four points
   which are very important.
   In what way are they impermanent?
   "The end of accumulation is
   dispersion or exhaustion."
   This is the first point.

2. You accumulate wealth, but at the end
   it exhausts — disperses, or reduces.
   There are some very rich people who at
   the end of their life have nothing:
   exhausted, consumed. If you read the
   history of the past you'll see.

3. Nowadays you see in some countries, when
   they become the leader of the country,
   with greed they accumulate so much.
   They have so much,
   but the people don't have anything.
   So now people are protesting —
   it's a cause of suffering —
   so they have to run away. Then, what's
   the benefit to accumulate all this?
   Look at this.

4. As I mentioned the other day,
   when you get a bowl of porridge or a
   few pieces of bread, you appreciate,
   you rejoice: "It's because of all the
   other people's support that I got this.
   I'm so fortunate. I appreciate,
   I rejoice, I'm content with that."
   And there's great peace,
   joy, because you appreciate.
   "So I'm so grateful."

5. We live moment to moment.
   We plan for the next day, we plan for
   next week, next month, next year.
   But who knows? It's indefinite.
   But we have now, and now is the time
   to practice Dharma.

6. Now is the time we have total freedom
   about how to manage our mind.
   So impermanence practice is such a
   powerful way to manage our mind,
   moment to moment.

0. The end of construction is falling [13:45–15:22]

Meditate "All constructions are like this"

1. Then, *"The end of construction is*
   falling." This is the second point.

2. You built buildings, built roads,
   built airplanes, railways, all the cars,
   tractors — all this, after some time you
   see it is falling, falling into parts.
   You constantly have to repair all
   of them.

3. Just for Buddhists,
   if anybody went to India…
   Once Buddhists became so powerful.
   You could go to the Bodhgaya,
   Nalanda area, Kushinagar, Lumbini:
   so many monasteries were built,
   hundreds and thousands of monks and nuns
   were there, but now you just see ruins.

4. So look at this, remind yourself,
   meditate on all of this.

0. The end of meeting is separating [15:22–17:15]

Prepare, and handle it wisely, carefully

1. Then, *"The end of meeting is separating."* This is the third point.

2. So all meetings in life are like that. Husband and wife, we meet, we met; or children are born, they meet their parents, parents meet their children. But at the end we separate. Maybe we stay together 50 years, 60 years, 70 years, even 100 years, but then one day we have to separate. Look at this.

3. So, as I mentioned earlier, it's about preparation so there is not so much pain. When we prepare, meditate on this, then when it actually happens there's not so much pain. Otherwise there's such great pain, desperate — you cry, and sometimes there is suicide.

4. So Buddha taught "This is the reality nature but you can handle it wisely, carefully." Instead, you should get so much benefit from this. Instead of going through so much suffering, try to get benefit from this.

5. So we need courage, wisdom, just like earlier I mentioned.

0. The end of life is death [17:15–20:26]

Liberation is in your hand

1. Then, *"The end of life is death."* This is the fourth point.

2. When we are born, it means one day we'll die. Mostly we know we'll die one day — we know it, because history can tell us there's no one who lived forever. Even if they live 100 years, 120 years, still they will die one day. It's clear, obvious. But when we are not prepared, then the suffering is so much. So we don't need suffering.

3. Without preparation, at that time we call this guru, that lama, that great teacher: "Can you help me? I'm going through so much suffering." Then what can the guru tell, what can the lama tell, you know?

4. So the Buddha directly talked to his followers: "I can give you all the instructions, all the methods" — as here Gampopa is teaching us — "but you have to apply yourself. Liberation is in your hand." So how grateful!

5. Buddha was not telling, "Bring all your offerings to me, I will do everything for you." Buddha was telling, "You have to sustain your life, you meditate your life. Live in the middle way, not too much, not too little." Everything in the middle, that way is manageable: you can manage your life. When there's too much, you cannot manage.

6. I saw there are some people
   who have a lot of collections,
   and they're suffering so much.
   They don't know what to do with those;
   they can't get rid of them,
   and they cannot keep them all.
   So Buddha is teaching us how to
   manage our life.

7. And then there comes the peace, there
   comes the joy, peace and happiness.
   And then it is not just only for
   this life, but for the next life and
   enlightenment, if one can manage.

0. These four include all impermanence [20:26–27:06]

The mind is the most important

1. So, these four: firstly,
   please contemplate these four,
   they are very important.
   These four include all the composite
   phenomena — the accumulation, the
   constructions, the meeting and the life.
   Within these four all the impermanence
   is included.

2. So reflect on these four subjects: first
   memorize them, and reflect on these,
   and then meditate on impermanence.

3. All the accumulations, at the end they
   will exhaust, they will disperse.
   And all the constructions,
   no matter how concrete you build,
   after some time they will fall — like
   airplanes, trains, roads, buildings.

4. And you see, all we met,
like in a meeting hall:
hundreds of people you meet,
and after some time everything is gone,
by themselves, separated. Look at this —
everything is just illusory nature.
At one point there are hundreds of
thousands of people in a big hall;
after a few hours they are all gone,
and the hall becomes empty.
That's called illusion.
If that is not an illusion,
then what is an illusion?

5. Reflect on this.
In the morning, a beautiful flower;
in the afternoon it fades, it decays.
So, like that.

6. So meditate on this.
Appreciate the opportunity you have,
appreciate the health you have:
"I must use it to practice Dharma."
Dharma practice means to
improve our mental quality.
The mind is the most important,
as you can see.

7. Buddha taught the complete nature of the
mind — nothing is missing to achieve
complete enlightenment — the complete
nature of the mind in the relative state
and in the absolute state.

8. The modern scientists, neurologists,
they are working so hard to see the
mind, using all the telescopes,
all the machines. They cut the brain
into many pieces — "Where's the mind?"
— but they cannot find it.
They have to meditate themselves:
they have to get good shamatha and
special insight. Through these two
methods they can understand the mind.
Otherwise, through a machine they cannot
see, because machines are matter,
substance, and the mind is consciousness
— it's not matter.

9. We know we have a mind,
but we don't know how it is,
because our attention is completely,
always on the outside, not inside.

10. I wrote one book, "Samsara & Nirvana:
two sides of the same hand".
It is about how one side of the
mind works, and the other side,
how to see the non-duality.
It's a very complex subject.
So this is always to improve our mind,
to see the advance of the mind,
how to relax the mind.

11. Finally, I just want you to
reflect on these four topics.
First, this quotation — the Buddha said,
*"O nuns and monks, all composite
phenomena are impermanent."* It's very
simple, but a very powerful message.
And then next, those four topics.
Please reflect on this.

I. - II.A Gross, subtle and very subtle impermanence [27:06–31:43]

How much we are deluded

1. Then next, the summary of this impermanence: *"classification, method of meditation and beneficial effects of meditation."* These three comprise all the contemplation on impermanence, and these are very nicely described in this book. You just read it and it's not so difficult to understand.

2. So first is outer phenomena, inner phenomena. Outer is the whole universe: the gross impermanence, and then subtle impermanence, and very subtle impermanence. So these are examples on how to practice impermanence, step by step.

3. First, when you look at the mountains, like the rocky mountains, all this looks very solid. They are like a rock — so silent, unmovable — but they are impermanent. So meditate on that.

4. Then, after the gross impermanence, go to a little more subtle impermanence. See the four seasons, how the four seasons change. And then day and night: just see how everything is impermanent.

5. Then very subtle impermanence: like the running of the river. The continuation, the running of the river, is so continuously changing. I don't realize how it is changing, but it's changing so… every second it is changing.

6. So we are deluded to perceive that, because the continuity is similar. That's why I say, "I saw this river last year", "I saw this river yesterday." Actually, it's gone; it's gone to the ocean. What I'm seeing now, today, is different from yesterday. But I am deluded to see the same river that I saw yesterday and today. So how deluded we are, you see?

7. So the river is constantly changing. Past is past, future is future, but, like the river, this present moment is changing. That means that nature itself is emptiness. So through this practice, meditation, from the impermanence you can realize the emptiness. So meditate on this.

8. And that's your mind — how your mind can change and can improve. For example, "Oh yes, my friend — first I like so much, and by just one instance, then I say I don't like you." Everything is kind of delicate, changing. So meditate on this.

9. So that is the Mahamudra, Dzogchen. That's very profound, but because our gross mind finds it difficult to comprehend, we don't see it that way. That's the impermanence of the outer phenomena.

II.B Impermanence of the Inner Sentient Beings [31:43–38:50]

Preparing to die peacefully, joyfully

1. Then inner phenomena: sentient beings —
everyone in the world is impermanent.
Here it is called
"impermanence of others":
all sentient beings are impermanent.
And *"impermanence of oneself"*:
I also am in the state of impermanence;
I am also changing.

2. Just reflect, take a deep breath and
relax: "From last year to this year,
I changed one year — my life is shorter.
From last month, one month is gone.
From last week, one week is gone.
From yesterday, one day is gone.
Now, from this morning, one hour,
two hours are gone." Just meditate
like that: "That's my nature.
I'm changing every second."

3. So, that means, impermanence means,
no essence. There's no essence.
You look at a beautiful flower,
so precious, but that very beautiful
flower fades in one second.
So there's no essence; it's changing.
You can see that through your wisdom,
special insight: everything is changing,
everything is like a bubble,
everything is like a mirage.

4. So look at this, meditate and calm
your mind. Bring your mind to the
right place, relax there, meditate.
Then everything starts to be natural.

5. So this way we are preparing for our
death — to die peacefully, joyfully.
Sometimes we put so much attention
on the bardo, like the instructions
on what to do in the bardo,
phowa and this and that.
But if you are not prepared,
these instructions will do nothing.
So we have to prepare step by step.

6. So here it tells us about how we will
die. Sometimes death is threatening:
"You will die." "Oh, I don't like that.
This is scary." But we have to prepare,
prepare peacefully, joyfully,
through the Dharma practice.

7. Gampopa explains, *To meditate on death,
one should think: "I myself cannot
stay long in this world and will
have to leave for the next life."*
So I have to prepare.

8. But what does preparing for death mean?
Contemplate this way: *Meditate on
the characteristic of death by
contemplating, "my life ends…"*
At the time of death, what happens?
This breath that I'm breathing
will cease to exist, and *"…
this body becomes a corpse."*
When the breath stops,
this way a person is dead. And this
mind leaves the body — *"…and this mind
has to wander in different places."*
— dependent on the conditions.
So meditate on this.

9. So at that time, instead of my mind
following the wrong direction —
attachment, aversion —
my mind maintains in the bodhicitta,
my mind maintains within the Mahamudra.
My mind maintains in the loving
kindness: “May every sentient being
have peace and happiness. May every
sentient being be free from suffering.
May they all achieve enlightenment,
including people who don’t like me.”
Everything is illusory nature.
There’s nothing to attach… just a
manifestation of causes and conditions.
I maintain my mind in the peace.
This is so precious. This is the best
way of the transition of our death,
and so impermanence is so precious.

10. So this is the practice of impermanence,
how to practice impermanence.
Reflect your mind in this way.

II.B Utilize this body to benefit others [38:50–44:48]

The power of contemplating impermanence

1. There are details on the impermanence of sentient beings; you can read those. I don't have to go through all the steps. But there's one point: "I cherish this body so much. I sacrifice, I sacrifice many things for this body, but at the time of death I have to leave this body behind. All the negative karma that I have created to protect this body — when I die the body is left behind, but the karma that I made I have to carry life after life."

2. So instead of cherishing this body, attached to this body, utilize this body to practice bodhicitta, to practice the Dharma, and utilize this body to benefit others — how to help others. So these are some important points you can pick up from this impermanence.

3. Then you'll be so happy to help others, to benefit others. We all are impermanent; we will change, so relax the mind in that. Instead of being upset, being angry, just relax the mind and meditate on this, and then do all the things that you can do to help others, to help yourself, to meditate yourself.

4. This way, look at our mind. As mentioned, the habitual tendencies, the inveterate propensities, look so concrete, so stubborn, but their nature is impermanent, their nature is emptiness. So if I make the effort, I can do it, because they are impermanent.

5. No matter how much I am so habituated in this samsaric habit, still their nature is impermanent, emptiness. So I can make it happen, to purify them. So this is the power of contemplating impermanence.

6. Relax, meditate. This way you always feel so light, not much burden. Release all your burden and practice the Dharma, and especially bodhicitta.

7. Instead of only focusing on this life, focus on enlightenment, on buddhahood. So, "I should use this body not only for this life's enjoyment, but I should use this body for the enlightenment of all sentient beings."

8. So for this, reading the life stories of great masters is so precious, how they have practiced, how they have benefited sentient beings.

9. So, as mentioned, it's not just a religious training. Our inveterate mind of habits is so arrogant. So the training of the mind is so that we can break through this arrogant mind, make the mind flexible, make the mind like space.

10. Impermanence has a lot of subjects there; you can read them, and as I mentioned, it's so precious. Then look at this: whenever you see people dying, reflect, "One day it will also happen to me like this. I must practice Dharma." Just remind yourself of this, again and again.

III. The beneficial effects [44:48–49:08]

Release attachment and hatred

1. So, through these
   practices of impermanence,
   then come the beneficial effects.
   Here: *"Awareness of the impermanence of all composite phenomena leads one to release attachment to this life."*

2. When we repeat this, meditate
   on this, then our attachment,
   our pernicious attachment, is purified,
   and the mind becomes spacious.
   And then that spacious mind has such a
   great opportunity to develop bodhicitta.

3. *"Further, it nourishes faith,"*
   When you look at the impermanence
   of all phenomena, then our faith,
   our interest in enlightenment,
   becomes strong — not only for this life,
   but for enlightenment, to help others.

4. *"…it supports perseverance,"*:
   life is impermanent, "I must practice.
   I cannot stay lazy."
   In the morning you get up and do
   practice; in the evening you practice;
   during the daytime, do meditation
   practice as often as possible —
   because everything is impermanent.

5. Even if you just watch the breath,
   relax, meditate, and contemplate
   everyone's desire for peace and
   happiness — because of that, reflect on
   the loving kindness, compassion.

6. *"… and it quickly frees one from attachment and hatred."*
   So through this mindfulness of
   impermanence, it helps us to release
   our attachment, our aversion, hatred.
   As earlier I mentioned,
   when this attachment and hatred are
   purified that's the real peace that can
   be experienced in the mind.

7. There are some individuals…
   very vicious to you.
   So if we are kind of vicious back
   to that individual, then our hatred
   mind brings a lot of pain, suffering:
   "How can I get rid of this person?
   How should I respond to this?"

8. Instead, reflect:
   this person is so stupid, ignorant,
   doesn't know how to handle, doesn't
   know how to bring peace and happiness;
   he or she is suffering so much.
   All these are impermanent,
   moment to moment changing, and that
   person doesn't know how to do that.

9. So you reflect about the suffering
   of that person and develop love
   and compassion, and all your
   mental suffering just disappears.
   That disappearing of that suffering is
   called the practice of emptiness.

III. Equal nature of all phenomena [49:08–55:14]

Don't treat impermanence as some small subject

1. There's no "big thing" about emptiness.
   Everything stands within the emptiness.
   Everything functions within emptiness,
   manifests from emptiness,
   dissolves into emptiness.
   If you know this, are aware of this,
   then you can relax, meditate there,
   and appreciate Dharma.

2. That's why the relative state and
   the absolute are non-duality.
   We don't make them non-duality, but
   their nature is within the non-duality.
   We make duality, and then we suffer.
   But if we have the wisdom to see how
   they function within the non-duality,
   the peace is in our hand.

3. So this is the wisdom of the Buddha, the
   wisdom of Gampopa. So meditate on this.
   That's why it says here, "…
   it becomes a cause for the realization
   of the equal nature of all phenomena" —
   that means emptiness.

4. When you practice this way, step by
   step, then you see, as I mentioned,
   the impermanence of every second.
   Then you divide: past is past,
   future is future, and you cannot
   find now something permanent.
   That itself is emptiness.

5. All this gross that we see, all the
   dust particles we see: if you divide,
   investigate through the intellect,
   it functions within the emptiness.
   Like, for example,
   the modern quantum physics theory.
   The scientists there have now proved,
   or they've realized, that all these
   dust particles are nothing but empty.
   But they don't know how to meditate
   on them, so they got rid of it: "This
   is empty, now we cannot do anything.
   No use."

6. But for us, emptiness is the best
   thing we can use: "Yes, there's
   nothing that functions independently;
   their nature is emptiness. There's
   nothing to attach to, nothing to hate."
   So that understanding itself is
   the wisdom. Through that wisdom,
   we get all the excellent opportunities
   to purify all the mental afflictions.

7. Meditate, and that develops such great
   love and compassion, special insight,
   and it can really bring peace in
   the world. I wish all the great
   scientists would realize that —
   how to meditate on emptiness —
   and bring peace in the world.

8. So we follow that path, then life is
   beautiful with a precious human life.
   That is what makes life so precious.
   Instead of the center of the problems,
   instead of the center of all
   the suffering, the life becomes
   the center of the peace,
   happiness and joy to all others.
   This is what is called Dharma practice,
   and there you can practice the
   bodhicitta.

9. So this big subject of impermanence,
   so many pages we have covered.
   Reflect on this, meditate, relax.
   Not just today, as mentioned,
   but in your daily life.
   In the morning, reflect on impermanence;
   meditate on loving kindness, compassion.
   In the evening, reflect on the
   bodhicitta; you go to sleep with the
   bodhicitta, or with all the other
   practices you have.

10. But impermanence! Don’t treat
    impermanence as some small thing.
    Impermanence is so important, from the
    beginning to the end of your practice.

Milarepa's broken clay pot [55:14–59:34]

From good or bad, we get good teachings

1. I usually repeat this life story
   of Milarepa. He had a clay pot.
   He was walking from one place to
   another, and his foot stepped on a piece
   of rock; he fell down, and the pot broke
   into pieces, unexpectedly.

2. So that amazed Milarepa so much: "Oh,
   the pot I had just one second ago,
   now it's in pieces here. This is all
   my collection of the world's wealth."
   He doesn't have anything, only the pot,
   and that broke.

3. Now, if it had happened to us,
   we would cry: "I'm so unfortunate.
   Generally I have nothing,
   but now my only pot is broken.
   How can I live? There's nothing I can
   cook the nettles in." Oh, we would cry,
   and then we are just outraged.

4. But Milarepa was so appreciative,
   rejoicing in the profound teaching
   that he received from this:
   "All the wealth that I have,
   the pot, is now broken into pieces.
   This becomes such a profound,
   great teacher who gave me this profound
   teaching: everything is impermanent,
   especially this precious human life."

5. Before that, he had the sense, "This is
   my pot," in his hand. When it broke,
   that sense in the mind disappeared;
   he released that attachment.
   The small attachment that Milarepa had
   totally vanished in that instant, and
   he received such a profound teaching.
   And that became such a powerful teacher.

6. So we can all get lessons: from good or
   bad, we get good teachings like this.
   So we can sustain our practice
   by reflecting on impermanence.
   We can appreciate whatever we have
   through reflecting on impermanence.
   This precious human life that we have,
   every day we can utilize it in the
   best way, not wasting it.

7. Whether you are walking, whether you
   are eating, whether you are sleeping,
   any time, reflect on impermanence.
   Then we can practice the Dharma —
   so precious.

8. So now, thank you, thank you
   everybody, thank you so much.
   Tomorrow we'll reflect on suffering
   and karma, cause and effect.
   Now please take a deep breath,
   and then say some dedication prayer.